Consent Capture — Setup & Configuration Guide

This guide walks you through setting up the **Consent Capture** plugin from start to finish. Consent Capture lets your staff record a patient's consent right from the chart, files each one as a documented FHIR `Consent`, and turns the chart's **Consents** button red (alongside a chart/profile banner) whenever a patient still owes a **required** consent. You configure everything (which consents exist, the wording, the questions) without writing any code.

Who this guide is for: the person setting the plugin up for your practice (a Canvas administrator). No coding required.

About how long it takes: roughly 30–45 minutes the first time, most of it spent writing the consent wording in Step 5.

> ⚠️ **A note on the Canvas admin screens.** A few steps happen in Canvas itself, outside this plugin. Canvas occasionally moves menus, so anywhere the exact click path might differ on your instance, you'll see a **"Verify this path in your instance"** note. Treat those as "look for something like this," and confirm the real location in your Canvas.

Before you start

Make sure you have all of these. If you're missing one, get it before continuing.

- ☐ **Canvas administrator access** (you can reach the Admin settings area).
- ☐ Permission to **create a FHIR API application** in Canvas (to get a client ID and secret). If you can't do this yourself, ask whoever manages your Canvas API access.
- ☐ A **list of the consents** your practice needs to capture (for example: Treatment Consent, Remote Patient Monitoring, Telehealth).
- ☐ The **Consent Capture plugin files** (this folder), ready to install. Installation is covered in Step 3.

Step 1 — Create your consent types in Canvas

The consents your staff can record are the **Patient Consent Codings** that live in Canvas admin. **The plugin does not create these** — it lists the ones you set up here and lets you add wording and questions to each. So this is where you decide *which* consents exist.

Do this once for each consent your practice needs:

1. Sign in to Canvas as an administrator.
2. Go to the **Admin** settings area and open **Patient Consent Codings**.

> ⚠️ **Verify this path in your instance.** Look for "Patient Consent Coding" (or "Consent Coding") under the Admin settings. The exact menu label can vary.

3. Click **Add** (or the **+**) to create a new coding.
4. Fill in:
   - **Display** — the name staff will see, e.g. `Remote Patient Monitoring Consent`.
   - **System** and **Code** — the coding's identifiers. If you don't have a standard to follow, a simple internal value is fine (for example system `INTERNAL` and a short code like `RPM`). Write these down; you'll recognize the consent by them later.
   - **Expiration rule** — how long the consent stays valid: **Never**, **Expires one year after acceptance**, or **Expires at end of year**. (Expiration is controlled here, not in the plugin.)
   - **Mandatory / Proof required** — set these per your practice's policy if your Canvas shows them.
5. Save.
6. Repeat for every consent type you want to capture.

> 💡 You can always come back and add more consent types later. New codings show up in the plugin's Consent Settings automatically.

Step 2 — Create FHIR API credentials

When staff record a consent, the plugin saves it through the Canvas **FHIR API**. To do that it needs its own **client ID** and **client secret**. You create those once here.

1. In Canvas admin, open the area for **API / third-party applications** (where OAuth applications are registered).

> ⚠️ **Verify this path in your instance.** Look for something like "Third-party application," "OAuth application," or "API client" under Admin settings.

2. Create a **new application**.
3. Give it a recognizable name, e.g. `Consent Capture Plugin`.
4. Grant it permission to:
   - **Create** `Consent` resources (to save new consents), and
   - **Read** `Consent` and `Binary` resources (to show the recorded document later).

> ⚠️ If your instance uses scope strings, these correspond to write access for Consent and read access for Consent and Binary. Verify the exact scope names in your instance.

5. Save the application. Canvas will show you a **client ID** and a **client secret**.
6. **Copy both somewhere safe right now.** The secret is usually shown only once. You'll paste them into the plugin in the next step.

> 🔒 Treat the client secret like a password. Don't email it or paste it into a chat. You'll store it as a **sensitive** plugin variable in the next step.

Step 3 — Install the plugin and set its variables

Install the plugin

Install Consent Capture on your instance the same way you install other plugins.

- If you use the command line:

```
uv run canvas install ./consent_capture --host <your-canvas-host>
```

- If you use the Canvas plugin admin UI, upload/enable the plugin there instead.

> ⚠️ **Verify this path in your instance.** Use whichever plugin-installation method your team already uses for this Canvas instance.

Set the plugin variables

Open the plugin's **variables / configuration** screen and set the values below.

> ⚠️ **Verify this path in your instance.** Plugin variables are set on the installed plugin's configuration screen in the Canvas plugin admin. Look for "Variables," "Secrets," or "Configuration" on the Consent Capture plugin.

Variable	Required?	What to enter
`CANVAS_FHIR_CLIENT_ID`	**Yes**	The **client ID** from Step 2.
`CANVAS_FHIR_CLIENT_SECRET`	**Yes**	The **client secret** from Step 2. (Stored as sensitive.)
`CONSENT_ADMIN_USERS`	**Yes**	Who is allowed into the admin pages (Consent Settings and the banner page). A list of **staff IDs**, separated by commas, semicolons, or new lines. Names aren't accepted. If you **leave it empty, nobody can open the admin pages**, Canvas Support included. Step 4 shows how to find your staff ID.
`CONSENT_BANNERS_ENABLED`	No	Turns the **"Required consent not on file." banner** on or off. Leave it as `true` (the default) to keep banners. Set it to `false` to turn banners off everywhere — then run the banner refresh (Step 6) once to clear existing banners immediately. This only affects the banner; the chart button is unaffected.
`CONSENT_SYSTEM`	No	Leave it as `INTERNAL`. This is a legacy default and is rarely needed.

> ✅ **Set `CONSENT_ADMIN_USERS` before go-live.** Until you do, nobody can reach Consent Settings or the banner tools. List the staff IDs of the people who should manage consents, for example: `0f1e2d3c4b5a69788796a5b4c3d2e1f0, 1a2b3c4d5e6f70819203a4b5c6d7e8f9`.

Step 4 — Confirm it's live

Let's make sure the plugin is installed and you have admin access.

1. Stay signed in to Canvas.
2. In your browser, go to: `https://<your-canvas-host>/plugin-io/api/consent_capture/admin/settings`
3. What you should see:
   - **The Consent Settings page** → 🎉 you're set. The plugin is installed and you have admin access. Continue to Step 5.
   - **A "You don't have access" message** → the plugin is installed, but you're not on the admin list. The message shows **Your staff ID**. Add it to `CONSENT_ADMIN_USERS` (Step 3) and reload.
   - **A page-not-found / error** → the plugin isn't installed or enabled yet. Revisit Step 3.

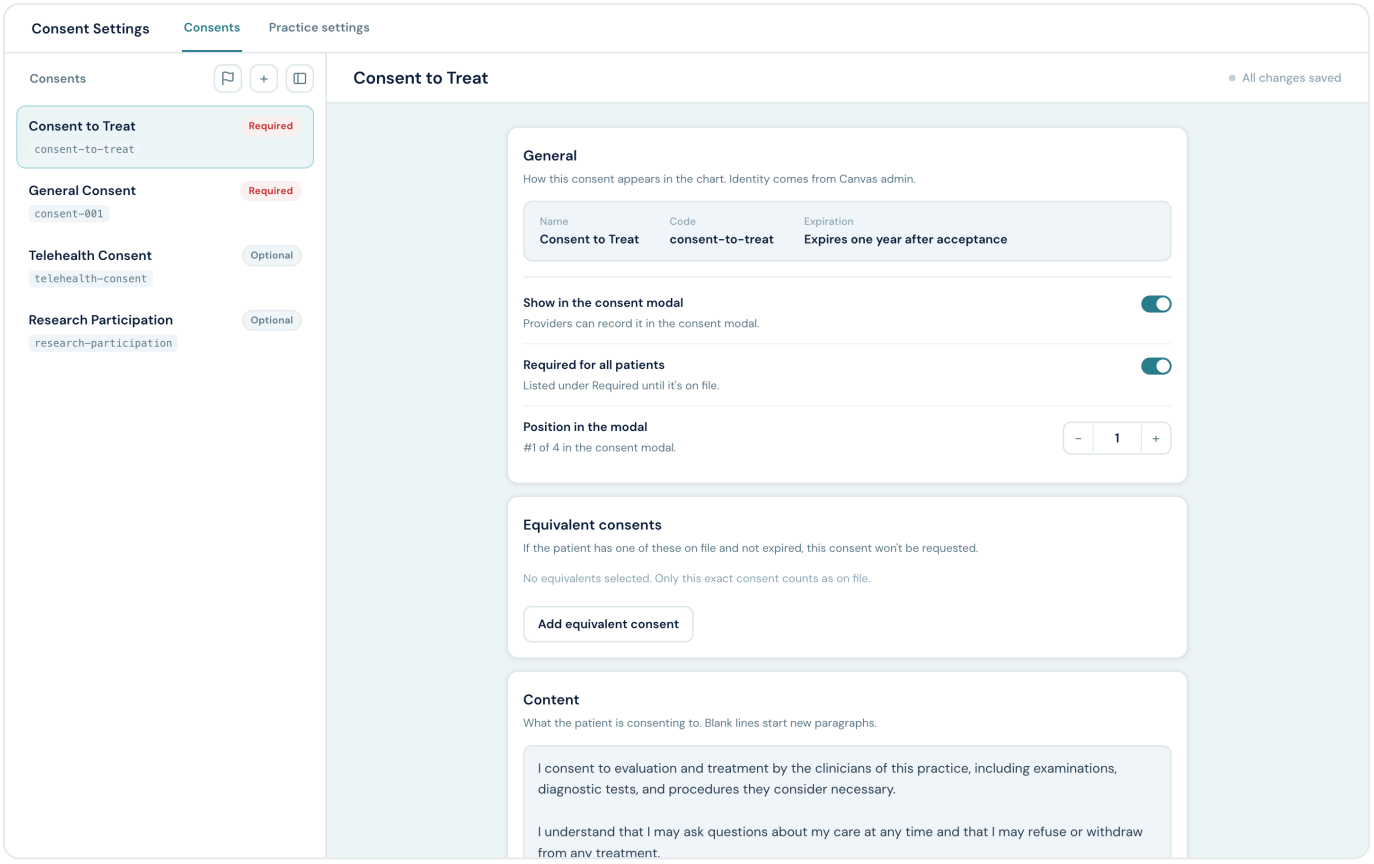
Step 5 — Configure each consent

Now you'll add the wording, questions, and options to each consent type. This is where the plugin comes to life.

Open Consent Settings

Consent Settings is its own page. Open it either way:

- Go to `https://<your-canvas-host>/plugin-io/api/consent_capture/admin/settings`, or
- Click the **gear icon** in the top-right of the consent picker (shown to admins).



Pick a consent from the list

The left column lists your consents, each with a status badge:

- **Required** — patients must have it; it drives the red button and the banner.
- **Optional** — staff can record it, but it's not chased.
- **Not shown** — hidden from the recording picker (staff can't record it right now).
- **Not set up** — a coding exists in Canvas but hasn't been configured here yet.

Also in this list:

- The **+** button opens Canvas admin so you can add a new consent coding (Step 1).
- The small **flag icon** opens the "Refresh Consent Banners" page (Step 6).

Click a consent to edit it.

Fill in the consent

Work down the editor. Each part is described below.

- **General** — the name, code, and expiration. These are **read-only** here because they come from the Canvas coding (Step 1). To change them, edit the coding in Canvas admin.
- **Toggles** — turn each on or off:
  - **Show in the consent modal** — whether staff can *record* this consent from the picker.
  - **Prompt as due now** — marks the consent **required**. When on, the consent shows under **Required** and drives the red button and the banner until it's on file.
  - **Ask how consent was obtained** — staff pick a method at capture (see below).
  - **Ask who is giving consent** — the patient, or a representative (name + relationship).
  - **Include a capacity statement** — adds a decision-making capacity line to the record.
- **Content (verbiage)** — the consent language staff read to the patient and that prints on the record. **Leave a blank line between paragraphs** to keep the paragraph breaks.
- **Questions** — the affirmations staff must record, asked in order. Each question can be:
  - **Yes / No**, **Acknowledge**, or a **typed answer**;
  - marked **required**; and, for Yes/No, set to **must be Yes to record** (so consent can't be saved unless the patient answered Yes).
- **At capture** — the details staff confirm when recording:
  - **Methods offered** — any of **Verbal**, **Electronic**, **Written**, **Other**.

    > 💡 **Written is special.** Written consents attach the signed form. Staff photograph or upload the signed paper document, or, with **Allow signing on this device** on, the signer signs on the staff device and the plugin generates the PDF with the signature.

  - **Allow signing on this device** — adds **Sign on this device** to **Written** consents. Off by default.
  - **Who is giving consent** — patient or representative.
  - **Capacity statement** — uses `[Patient name]` and `[Name]` placeholders, which fill in automatically at capture.
- **Document preview** — a live preview on the right shows how the recorded PDF will read as you type. Use it to proofread.

Save

Click **Save changes**. Repeat Step 5 for every consent you want staff to use.

> ℹ️ **"Show in the consent modal" controls *recording*, not display.** A consent that's already on a patient's chart still appears under **On File** in the picker even if this toggle is off. The plugin never creates or edits codings, and expiration always lives on the coding in Canvas admin.

Practice settings

The **Practice settings** tab applies to every consent signed on the device:

- **Signing several consents** — **Sign each consent** (default) or **Allow reusing a signature**, which offers the signer's first signature on the rest of the consents in the same session.
- **Accepted signatures** — **Finger or stylus** and **Mouse or trackpad** (on by default), and **Typed** (off by default). At least one stays selected.
- **Ask for a printed name** — off by default. When off, the name from **Who is giving consent?** prints under the signature.

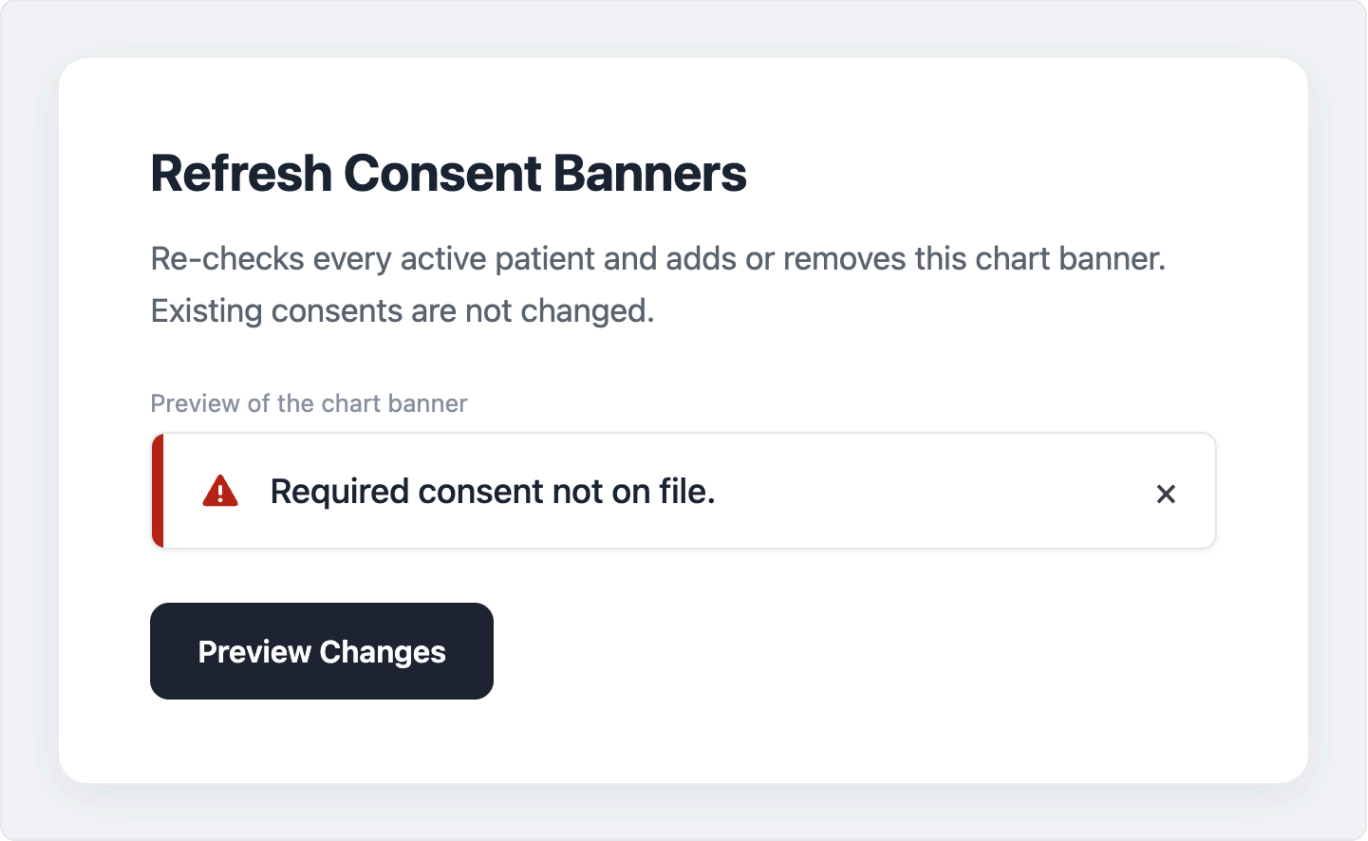
Click **Save changes** on that tab.

Step 6 — Turn on banners for patients already in the system

The red banner ("Required consent not on file.") updates automatically whenever something happens on a patient — a consent is recorded, or the patient record changes. That means **patients already in your system won't get the banner until their next event**, unless you give it a nudge here.

Run this once after you finish setting up your required consents (and again any time you make a new consent required):

1. Open the **Refresh Consent Banners** page:
   - Click the **flag icon** in Consent Settings, or
   - Go to `https://<your-canvas-host>/plugin-io/api/consent_capture/admin/banners`.
2. Click **Preview Changes**. This only *reports* how many banners would be added and removed. **It changes nothing.**
3. Review the numbers. If they look right, click **Apply Changes**. To back out, click **Cancel**.



> ✅ This never changes any recorded consents. It only adds or removes the banner on active patients to match who currently owes a required consent.

What your staff will see

Once you're set up, here's the day-to-day experience for clinical and front-desk staff.

Two ways a consent shows up in the chart:

1. A **Consents** button in the chart header — **always shown**. It turns **red** when the patient still owes a **required** consent, and is a neutral **gray** button once everything required is on file.
2. A red **banner** reading **"Required consent not on file."** on the chart and profile — clears automatically once every required consent is on file.

Recording a consent (4 steps):

1. Open the picker (any of the three surfaces above). Consents are grouped into **Required**, **Optional**, and **On File** (the patient's consent history).
2. Pick a consent and review the wording with the patient.
3. Confirm how consent was obtained, who is giving it, and answer any questions.
4. Click **Record Consent**. The plugin files it and it appears under **On File** right away.

> ℹ️ The **red** color and the banner **never appear for inactive or deceased patients** — their Consents button stays gray. If a patient is reactivated, the red color and banner come back on the patient's next event (or after a banner refresh, Step 6).

Troubleshooting

What you see	What to do
"You don't have access" on an admin page	Add the **Your staff ID** value from that page to `CONSENT_ADMIN_USERS` (Step 3), then reload.
A consent **won't record**, or a "credentials are missing" message	Recheck `CANVAS_FHIR_CLIENT_ID` and `CANVAS_FHIR_CLIENT_SECRET` (Steps 2–3). Confirm the API application can create `Consent`.
A consent **isn't in the picker** for staff to record	In Consent Settings, turn on **Show in the consent modal** for that consent (Step 5).
The **banner isn't showing** on a patient who should have it	Run **Refresh Consent Banners** (Step 6). The banner shows only for **active, non-deceased** patients who still owe a **required** consent — confirm the patient is eligible and that the consent is marked **Prompt as due now** (Step 5).
A consent shows under **On File** that you didn't record here	Expected. The plugin surfaces every consent on file, including ones recorded elsewhere or on codings it doesn't manage.

Quick reference

Key URLs (replace `<your-canvas-host>`):

Page	URL
Consent Settings	`/plugin-io/api/consent_capture/admin/settings`
Refresh Consent Banners	`/plugin-io/api/consent_capture/admin/banners`

Plugin variables:

Variable	Required?	Value
`CANVAS_FHIR_CLIENT_ID`	Yes	FHIR API client ID
`CANVAS_FHIR_CLIENT_SECRET`	Yes	FHIR API client secret (sensitive)
`CONSENT_ADMIN_USERS`	Yes	Staff IDs allowed into the admin pages; empty = nobody
`CONSENT_SYSTEM`	No	Leave as `INTERNAL`

For a technical/developer reference (components, security model, data access, tests), see the plugin's **README.md**.